

Comparative Analysis of Mark Carney in Canadian & U.S. Media Coverage

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Introduction

Mark Carney's emergence as a political figure in Canada has prompted growing interest in how he is portrayed across North American media. As Carney transitioned from a central banker to a political leader and, eventually, Prime Minister, our analysis suggests the volume and character of coverage surrounding him began to shift. This led us to wonder, *"How is Mark Carney perceived in North American media since and leading up to his term as prime minister of Canada, in tone and topic, across the political spectrum?"*. By analyzing 500 articles across major outlets representing the political left, center, and right, our project investigates not only whether coverage is positive, negative, or neutral, but also how the media depicts Carney's political identity through recurring narratives seen throughout our dataset.

In doing so, we examine how the national context and political alignment influence the narratives that are told about Carney. Our analysis shows that Canadian and American outlets tend to emphasize different aspects of his role, and that topic choices and evaluative tone/sentiment vary systematically across the political spectrum. We also observe apparent differences in how frequently Carney is portrayed critically, neutrally, or favorably. Taken together, these patterns suggest that Carney's public image is not uniform, but instead is constructed differently depending on the audience and context, a theme we develop in detail in the results that follow.

Data

We used a mix of different methods, such as API extraction (via TheNewsAPI¹ and the New York Times API²) and manual scraping, to collect articles across Canadian and American media outlets.

Since our project focuses on the period since and leading up to Carney's term as prime minister, we filtered out articles before Sept. 1st, 2024, with September 2024 being the month in which Carney was appointed "as the Chair of a Leader's Task Force on Economic Growth" (Liberal Party of Canada 2024) under the Liberal Party.

Initially, we attempted to collect an equal number of articles from the U.S. and Canada (approximately 250 each); however, we found that there was less coverage of Carney in the U.S., which we attribute to his relatively new status as a political figure. Hence, we elected to use a 200/300 U.S. to Canada split to maintain a reasonable ratio that reflects fundamental coverage differences without making the number of Canadian articles disproportionately large.

Some factors that we took into consideration while selecting news sources are the following:

- *Country*: We wanted to collect articles from an equal number of sources for each country; however, due to the limited reporting on Carney by each American news outlet, with each source having on average at most 30+ articles, we had to choose more American sources than Canadian sources to reach our set quota of 200 articles (for the U.S.).
- *Political alignment and bias*: To account for the impact of political biases on the reporting, we selected news sources across the political spectrum (left, center, right). We relied on third-party analyses by All Sides and Ad Fontes Media to assess political bias in American media. Due to the lack of analyses on Canadian media, we relied on charts created by various netizens (Maliszewski 2021) to inform our selection.

For the United States, we selected six outlets evenly distributed across the political spectrum: two left-leaning sources (The Associated Press and The New York Times), two centrist outlets (The Wall Street Journal and United Press International), and two right-leaning sources (The New York Post and Fox News). For Canada, the sample included one left-leaning outlet (CBC), two centrist outlets, CTV News (center-right) and Global News (center-left), and one right-leaning outlet (National Post).

¹ TheNewsAPI: <https://www.thenewsapi.com/>

² The New York Times Developer Network: <https://developer.nytimes.com/apis>

We used a flexible quota system to collect articles from U.S. sources, aiming to collect 35 per source or as many as could be obtained. Missing articles, if any, were compensated for by collecting more from other outlets.

A similar method was employed for Canadian articles, with a flexible quota of 75 per news source. We chose to have an approximately equal number of articles per source, despite the greater number of centrist sources in Canada, as some charts suggest that CTV News is center-right, while Global News is center-left (Maliszewski 2021). We categorized both as center due to the ambiguity in bias assessment between charts.

This selection produced a dataset distributed as shown in Table 1.

		Political orientation			
		Left	Center	Right	Total
Country	US	70	60	70	200
	Canada	76	149	75	300
	Total	146	209	145	500

Table 1: Composition of Collected News Articles by Country and Political Orientation.

A limitation we do, however, recognize is that left- and right-biases are not the same in the U.S. as in Canada, with some reports and accounts stating that Canadian conservative (i.e., right) values lean more to the left than American conservative values (Adams and Parkin 2022).

Methods

After finalizing the dataset, we conducted open coding on 20 articles from each of our 10 sources to identify recurring themes and refine our typology. During this stage, we observed that several topics that we had originally grouped together required clearer separation. Articles concerning Canada–U.S. relations appeared frequently enough to warrant being split from the broader category of Canada’s international relations. Similarly, an early category we had made that blended Canadian politics, governance, and economic policy was subsequently divided into two more specific categories: the 2025 federal election and Canadian governance/economics. Additional categories, such as culture and social life, were introduced to accommodate recurring types of coverage, for example, reporting on lifestyle-oriented articles describing Carney’s public appearances at sporting events. By editing our typology in response to edge cases and ambiguities encountered during open coding, we ultimately divided our dataset into six distinct categories: *2025 Elections and Federal Parties*, *Canada-U.S. Relations*, *International Relations and Diplomacy*, *Canadian Governance and Economy*, *Biography and Opinion*, and *Culture and Social Life*.

While thinking ahead for sentiment analysis, we anticipated the most clearly negative or positive articles to be opinion pieces, which would a potential skew in categories such as *Biography and Opinion*. In an attempt to address this, we adopted an evaluative rule in which articles portraying a success or favourable outcome for Carney were coded as positive, and those depicting setbacks or unfavourable outcomes were coded as negative. Those that do not particularly refer to him in either manner were annotated as neutral. This decision allowed tone to be assessed more consistently across both factual reporting and commentary.

To identify the most characteristic terms within each topic category, we manually implemented the computation of tf-idf. For each topic, the “document” was defined as the combined set of headlines and snippets belonging to that category. The formula used to compute tf-idf is:

$$\text{tfidf}(t, d, D) = \text{tf}(t, d) \cdot \text{idf}(t, D)$$

where $\text{tf}(t, d)$ is the normalized frequency of term t in document d , and $\text{idf}(t, D) = \log_{10} \{N / \#(d: t \in d)\}$.

Before computing tf-idf scores, all terms were lemmatized using Python’s NLTK library to reduce plural and inflectional variants to their root form. However, because lemmatization sometimes failed to collapse adjectival or demonstrative forms into their corresponding country (e.g., “Ukrainian” vs. “Ukraine”), we added a layer of custom lemmatization to address these cases. Additional limitations arose from inaccuracies in NLTK’s part-of-speech tagging, which led to incorrect lemmatizing (such as lemmatizing “does” to “doe” when the former is incorrectly identified as a noun instead of a verb). While we manually corrected the most frequent errors, some residual inconsistencies may have influenced the final tf-idf scores. Overall, this approach generated interpretable keyword profiles for each category while addressing the limitations during the preprocessing stage.

To complement the tf-idf analysis, we also used a large language model (LLM) to generate concise summaries of each topic category. These summaries were used to validate whether the tf-idf keywords accurately reflected the main themes and to ensure that our open-coding categories aligned with the patterns present across articles.

Results

Building on the procedures described in the Methods section, the topic annotation and aggregation steps yielded the following results.

Topic Definitions

We classified articles into six mutually exclusive topic categories:

1. *Canada and U.S. Relations*: Articles focused on political, economic, or diplomatic interactions between Canada and the United States, including tariffs, trade disputes, and bilateral meetings.
2. *International Relations & Diplomacy*: Articles addressing Canada's relations with foreign countries other than the United States, including multilateral summits and geopolitical engagements.
3. *Canadian Governance and Economy*: Articles covering Canadian government policy, economic decisions, industrial activity, and intergovernmental relations unrelated to the 2025 elections.
4. *2025 Elections and Federal Parties*: Articles concerning the 2025 federal elections, including campaigning, polling, party dynamics, and election outcomes.
5. *Biography and Opinion*: Articles offering biographical information, opinion or editorial commentary, or assessments of Carney's personal background and public image.
6. *Culture and Social Life*: Articles centered on cultural events, public appearances, entertainment, and sports-related activities involving Carney.

After refining our typology through multiple rounds of open coding, we found that we could effectively partition our entire dataset into these topics, without requiring an "Other" category. When any uncertainties arose, annotations were confirmed and verified between collaborators.

Topic Characterization

We aimed to characterize the topics we had chosen via tf-idf analysis on our dataset, and in this process, further validate our topic categorization. For each topic, we collected the top 10 terms with the highest tf-idf scores. For brevity, we present below an overview of our results and include all tf-idf scores in the appendix.

Canadian Governance and Economy: We have found that terms related to energy ("oil", "carbon", "energy", "pipeline"), budgets and bills ("table", "spending"), and Canadian premiers ("danielle smith", "david eby") had the highest tf-idf scores.

Canada and U.S. Relations: Top terms included "tariff", "washington", "oval office", "trade", being allusions to talks and policies between Canada and the U.S., and more specifically terms such as "vehicle", "steel", which refer to specific industrial sectors. Other keywords, such as "double", "ad", "non-us", and "revive", refer to actions and plans taken by Carney in response to pressures from the Trump Administration.

2025 Elections and Federal Parties: All terms, such as "election", "party", "liberal", "endorse", "campaign", "nepean" (the riding in which Carney ran), "federal", "riding", "voter", "candidate", and "race", were consistent with and a direct reference to the topic.

Biography and Opinion: The most frequent keywords were the names of columnists reporting on Carney (e.g.: "terry newman", "chris selley", "carson jerema", etc.) and the words "nothing" and "guy". The term "irish" was also among the top keywords due to articles covering Carney's Irish roots.

International Relations and Diplomacy: Many countries/territories and world leaders appeared most frequently in this topic, specifically surrounding subtopics like the Ukraine-Russia War ("ukraine"), Israel-Gaza conflict ("israel", "gaza", "recognize"), as well as trade and diplomatic talks ("trip", "macron", "xi", "india", "sign").

Culture and Social Life: As a whole, articles mostly mentioned events such as the Grey Cup in Winnipeg ("winnipeg", "grey cup", "oilers") and the World Series ("world series", "blue jays", "dodgers"), the latter for which Carney challenged Trump to a bet ("bet", "afraid"). Carney has also attended other events, including "parade[s]" and the inauguration of the "light rail" (REM) in Montreal.

All in all, we can observe that the top terms from each topic align with what we envisioned in our typology, while providing valuable insights into the actual stories being reported. This also gives us confidence that our dataset was annotated properly.

Aside from evaluating term frequencies, we also utilized LLM summaries to enhance our understanding of the topics. According to generated summaries, articles labeled under *Canada-U.S. Relations* consistently allude to Carney in terms of trade tensions, diplomatic strain, and policy divergence, which are elements that appear across the U.S. articles in this category. By contrast, the summaries for the other topics reflect content unrelated to bilateral issues, covering economic policy, multilateral diplomacy, elections, personal background, and public appearances, indicating that only the *Canada and U.S. Relations* topic centers on U.S.-Canada dynamics.

Topic Distribution

We first began examining the distribution of topics covered by American and Canadian media, respectively. Figure 1 below presents the distribution for U.S. news sources. The majority of American coverage is on *Canada-U.S. Relations* (51%), followed by *Elections and Federal Parties* (22%), while the remaining four categories collectively account for the remaining 27% of articles referencing Carney.

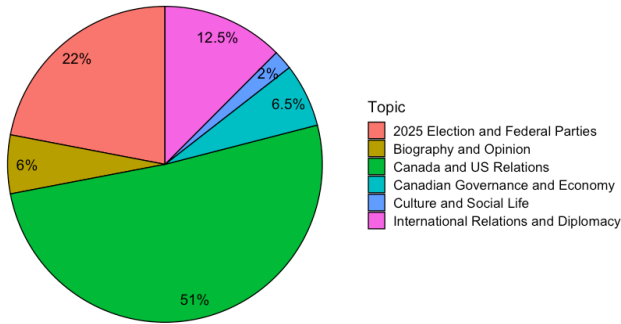


Figure 1: Topic Distribution within U.S. Articles

The corresponding topic distribution for Canadian news outlets shows a different trend, as seen in Figure 2. In contrast to the United States, coverage is more evenly divided across topics: *Domestic Governance/Economy* (28%), *Elections and Federal Parties* (22%), *Biography/Opinion* (22.33%), *International Relations & Diplomacy* (13.67%), and *Culture/Social Life* (5.33%). Notably, the *Canada-U.S. Relations* category comprises 8.67% of Canadian articles.

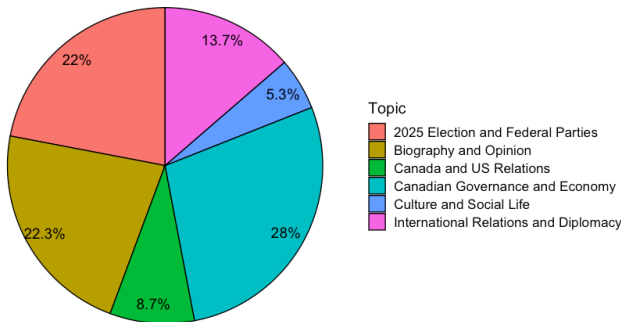


Figure 2: Topic Distribution within Canadian Articles

Beyond the proportions visible in Figures 1 and 2, cross-country comparisons reveal additional differences in the coverage distribution per country for each topic. Canadian sources constitute over 80% of all articles classified under *Biography/Opinion* and *Domestic Governance/Economy*, whereas U.S. sources account for nearly 80% of all articles tagged as *Canada-U.S. Relations*.

Sentiment Bias

For sentiment analysis, we explored how articles framing Carney in a positive, neutral, and negative light were distributed across sources based on their political bias and country. In Figure 3, we present charts to illustrate the percentage of each sentiment within each combination of country and political leaning.

When considering the distribution without distinguishing between countries, we see that a neutral tone was employed the most in articles by all left, center, and right-leaning

sources, at 79.5%, 83.7%, 52.4%, respectively. After filtering by country and political bias, we observe that most coverage remains predominantly neutral in all country-political bias combinations, except in right-leaning Canadian sources, where the most vocal sentiment is negative at 61.3%, compared to 34.7% neutral.

We also note an increase in positive coverage the further left the sources are on the political spectrum. And, contrastingly, negative coverage increases the further right along the spectrum the sources are. In both countries, negative sentiment was significantly higher in right-leaning sources than in left-leaning and center sources. Positive sentiment does not fluctuate as much with respect to political bias. These observations are reflected by the percentages in Figure 3.

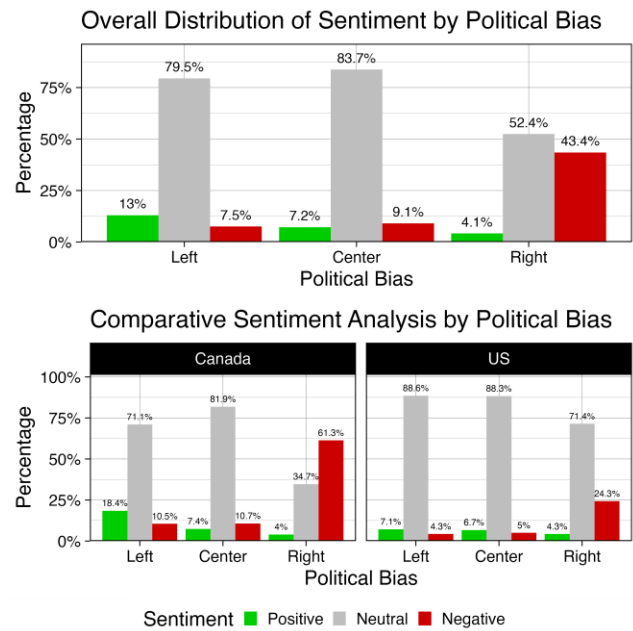


Figure 3: Sentiment Analysis by Political Bias

Additionally, when we consider both topics and sentiment bias simultaneously, we note that of all articles on *Biography/Opinion*, 72.15% of them report on Carney negatively, while negative coverage is below 15% within all other topics. Within the negative press, 61.29% of articles were labelled as *Biography/Opinion*.

Discussion

Our analysis indicates media bias towards Mark Carney in 2 distinctive ways. The discussion first addresses the skew in topic coverage, exploring which domains receive the most attention by North American media. We then discuss the skew in negative coverage, scrutinizing the contrast in

sentiment where right-leaning media in both the U.S. and Canada contributed the most in reporting Carney critically.

Skew in Topic Coverage

We have found a significant difference in the distribution of topics covered by American and Canadian sources. Firstly, *Canada-U.S. Relations* are the primary and dominant lens under which Mark Carney is presented by U.S. news, with 51% of all American articles labelled as such, as opposed to only 8.7% of all Canadian articles (see Figures 1 and 2). Furthermore, nearly 80% of all *Canada-U.S. Relations* articles come from the United States. The prevalence of this topic in American news is expected, given that Carney is a Canadian politician. His relevance to the American populace would, understandably, primarily be through Canada's involvement with the United States. The additional context of the "trade" disputes, "tariff" conflicts, and diplomatic tensions between the two countries, as highlighted by the LLM summary and tf-idf analysis on this topic, demonstrates that Carney appears mainly when bilateral issues become prominent.

On a different note, as illustrated by Figure 2, we argue that Canadian coverage is more diverse and balanced, with it being more evenly spread out across several topic categories. We recall that the top 4 out of 6 topics, i.e. *Domestic Governance/Economy* (28%), *Biography/Opinion* (22.3%), *Elections/Campaigning* (22%), and *International Relations* (13.7%) each make up substantial portions of the Canadian reporting on Carney, with no topic dominating it, unlike in the U.S., as discussed earlier. To add to this point, over 80% of all *Biography/Opinion* and *Domestic Governance* articles originate from Canadian outlets, which also highlights how little U.S. news discusses these topics, among others.

Examining more closely, a key matter mentioned in many articles on *Domestic Governance/Economy* is Carney's stance on the oil industry in Alberta, and whether future pipeline projects would be approved. This is evidenced by how "oil", "danielle smith" (who is Alberta's premier), and "pipeline" were top terms from our tf-idf analysis. Additionally, as summarized by ChatGPT, articles on internal policies, cabinet pressures, and public appearances characterize this topic. As such, it is within expectation that U.S. sources would not cover topics like these.

Taken together, many results show that American coverage primarily limits Carney's visibility to cross-border issues and tensions, whereas Canadian coverage presents him as a more complex political actor, providing Canadian audiences with a far more comprehensive and diverse range of perspectives on his role as Prime Minister.

Skew in Negative Coverage

In addition, we noticed that right-leaning media outlets are more critical of Mark Carney than left and center-leaning ones, in both Canada and the U.S.

Indeed, if we look at the distribution in tone across the political spectrum, regardless of the country, the reporting becomes more and more negative the further right along the political spectrum the sources are, with 7.5%, 9.1%, and 43.4% of articles by left, center, and right-leaning sources, respectively, being negative. This trend persists even when we examine negative coverage by country, with changes from 10.5% to 10.7% to 61.3% in Canadian news, and from 4.3% to 5% to 24.3% in American news (see Figure 3). All three jumps in percentages, when transitioning from center to right-leaning sources, are significant, which supports our assessment.

We also recall from our results that, among Canadian right-leaning sources, the majority of coverage of Carney is negative (61.3%). So not only do right-leaning sources report more critically than left-leaning and center sources, but their coverage of Carney is also predominantly negative. The latter conclusion, however, does not stand for American right-leaning media, which stands at 24.3% negative and is not majoritarian.

Consequently, our analysis reveals that right-leaning media outlets tend to portray Carney in a more negative light than their counterparts. Moreover, it is worth noting that the coverage of Carney by Canadian right-leaning outlets is predominantly more negative compared to the coverage by American right-leaning media, which aligns with our findings.

Another observation we make is the potential association between the topic *Biography/Opinion* and negative sentiment. With over 70% of coverage on that topic being negative, and more than 60% of all negative coverage coming from articles labeled as *Biography/Opinion*, there may be a correlation between this topic and sentiment. The same trend could not be observed for any other pairing of topic and sentiment.

If we look specifically at the coverage of Carney by our Canadian right-leaning source, the National Post, we find numerous examples of opinion pieces in which authors dispute his previous accomplishments and challenge his current policies. For example, the headline "Conrad Black: Mark Carney has poor values" is a direct attack on Carney's character. In the same paper, Black asserts that "Canadians cannot possibly support his plans for global climate policy" (2025), targeting Carney's stance and policies.

A closer look at the words used within the National Post's opinion pieces also reveals the prevalence of the word "guy" (which was among the top ten terms with the highest tf-idf scores in the *Biography/Opinion* category) when discussing

Carney. Such an example is Terry Glavin's piece, whose headline, "Who is this Mark Carney guy, anyway?" (2025), questions Carney's abilities while simultaneously presenting him in a belittling manner, as a random and generic individual. In the same article, Glavin states that Carney is "almost cartoonish" (2025), a phrasing that further contrasts Carney's established figure with a caricature.

We observe a general trend in the language employed by National Post columnists, with many words and phrases that carry a negative connotation. Considering the opposing sides of the political spectrum on which the National Post and Mark Carney, representing the center-left establishment as leader of the Liberal Party, stand, it is understandable that opinion pieces, and most importantly, negative reporting, mostly come from right-leaning media.

Conclusion

Across our analysis, a clear story emerged about how Mark Carney is positioned within North American media. As Carney took on a more prominent political role, the reporting around him did not just increase, it split up into a variety of narratives shaped by country, political orientation, and journalistic perception. By drawing on a collection of 500 articles, we received a broader depiction of a political figure portrayed very differently depending on who is doing the reporting.

American outlets tend to report on Carney at moments of diplomatic tension. As a result, U.S. coverage frames him less as a domestic leader and more as a Canadian counterpart in instances of conflict, trade disputes, or political gestures. In contrast, Canadian media have a more varied depiction of Carney's political identity, following him through election campaigns, governance decisions, international diplomacy, and even moments of his personal life. The unevenness between these perspectives reflects not only differing national interests but also distinct ideas about what aspects of Carney matter to their respective audiences.

Political bias further shapes these portrayals. In both countries, right-leaning outlets produced substantially more negative coverage than centrist or left-leaning ones, with Canadian right-leaning sources showing the strongest negative skew. Much of this negativity is concentrated in Biography and Opinion pieces, suggesting that editorial framing plays a key role in shaping Carney's public image.

Taken together, these patterns suggest that Mark Carney does not appear in the media as a single, coherent figure. Instead, he is perceived through multiple lenses, each showing us a slightly different version of who he is and what he represents. Therefore, our analysis illustrates how variations in media context across North America shape not only the

tone and topic of coverage, but ultimately the public understanding of political figures like Carney.

Future avenues of exploration could include looking at coverage on Mark Carney within city and regional Canadian papers (e.g. Toronto Star, Vancouver Sun, Montreal Gazette, Ottawa Citizen, etc.) and examining whether there are any differences in how he is discussed and perceived across geographical regions. An analysis of the coverage by French-language media in Canada (e.g.: La Presse, Le Journal de Montréal, Le Devoir, etc.) versus English-language media could also be interesting.

Group Member Contributions

All group members made substantial contributions to the project's completion. The data collection and open-coding process were undertaken jointly, with each member responsible for an equal share of sourcing articles and conducting initial topic identification (open coding). Annotation duties were also divided evenly, ensuring balanced and consistent coverage across the whole dataset. In the exploratory data analysis stage, all members participated in reviewing distributions, refining categories, and identifying patterns that would be used in the later stages of the project. Yun Jia conducted the tf-idf implementation and keyword extraction, while Chris and Noé were responsible for generating the LLM-based summaries for each topic category. The quantitative data analysis, including tone evaluation calculations and cross-group comparisons, was conducted by Zahra, Chris, and Noé. Finally, the written report was developed collectively, with drafting, editing, and revision work shared across the team to ensure coherence and accuracy in the final submission.

Appendix 1: Tf-idf Scores over all Topics

We present here the top ten terms that emerged for each topic, and their corresponding tf-idf scores. In cases of ties, we have included all tied terms, resulting in more than ten terms for some categories.

Canadian Governance and Economy

oil	0.003169
premier	0.001931
danielle smith	0.001794
carbon	0.001706
table	0.001463
david eby	0.001463
energy	0.001226
feminist	0.001219
spending	0.001196
pipeline	0.001103

Canada-U.S. Relations

tariff	0.002739
washington	0.001492
oval office	0.001321
double	0.001160
vehicle	0.000995
steel	0.000915
trade	0.000894
ad	0.000834
non-u.s	0.000829
revive	0.000829

2025 Elections and Federal Parties

election	0.002484
party	0.002191
liberal	0.002015
endorse	0.001506
campaign	0.001415
nepean	0.001291
federal	0.001120
voter	0.001076
race	0.000999
candidate	0.000999

Biography and Opinion

terry newman	0.003873
chris selley	0.002817
carson jerema	0.002465
jamie sarkonak	0.002113
conrad black	0.001761
michael higgins	0.001727
why	0.001511
geoff russ	0.001408
irish	0.001408
guy	0.001408
nothing	0.001408

International Relations and Diplomacy

ukraine	0.003638
uae	0.003307
trip	0.002636
macron	0.002315
xi	0.002028
india	0.001654
recognize	0.001654
israel	0.001654
gaza	0.001622
sign	0.001419

Culture and Social Life

world series	0.014213
game	0.010660
blue jays	0.010660
bet	0.007106
afraid	0.005922
dodgers	0.005922
parade	0.005922
team	0.005922
grey cup	0.004738
oilers	0.004738
light rail	0.004738
winnipeg	0.004738

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